StraightScale

The WORDS Sheet

12 copy-paste searches that find your buyers' exact sentences. One sitting: 20 minutes.

From StraightScale (@straightscale_). These are the searches we run before we make any content: the same method we used to collect 567 buyer sentences before our first video.

Why this works

If your posts and ads are not booking calls, the usual reason is that they sound like marketing. Your buyers have already described their problem in public, in their own words. Those sentences make better hooks than anything you can write, because buyers stop for their own words.

One rule for every search: **search with pain words, not product words.** Search "feast or famine", not "business coaching". People write pain words when they complain, and that is where the honest sentences are.

Before you start (2 minutes)

1. Open a blank doc with three columns: **FEAR**, **DESIRE**, **IDENTITY**.
2. Fill in these blanks. You will paste them into the searches below.
   - `[NICHE]` : what your buyer is, in their words (example: `agency owner`)
   - `[COMPETITOR]` : a competitor's name or website (example: a well-known coaching program in your space)
   - `[PAIN]` : a pain phrase your buyers use (example: `feast or famine`)
   - `[CITY]` : only if you sell locally (example: `London`)
3. No pain phrase yet? Start with these. Each one is a real phrase from our 567 sentences: `lumpy` , `feast or famine` , `sporadic` , `not predictable` , `black box` , `tried everything` , `zero sales` , `race to the bottom` .

In every search, copy the line in the grey box, paste it into the place named, and swap the blanks.

How to sort what you copy

Read each sentence once and drop it in one column. Unsure? Ask "is this what they're running from, what they're running to, or who they are?"

Column	It sounds like	A real example (source, date)
FEAR	what they lost, wasted, are tired of or afraid of again	"I paid $15,000 for appointment-setting services and, over four-plus months, received zero sales." (Trustpilot, 1 star, 29 Sep 2026)
DESIRE	what they want, often as a question or "I just want"	"How are you acquiring stable clientele outside of direct referrals?" (Reddit comment, collected Oct 2026)
IDENTITY	who they are, or refuse to be ("as a...", "I knew it")	"I was in a race to the bottom on pricing, and I knew it." (Substack, 30 Jan 2026)

Three rules:

- **Copy, never polish.** Paste the sentence exactly, typos included. Once it's polished, it sounds like an ad.
- **Write the source and date** next to each one. You will want to find it again.
- **Skip the vague ones.** "Great service!" tells you nothing. Keep sentences with a number, a time, a thing they tried, or a feeling.

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1. Competitors' Google reviews (3 minutes)

Search 1. In Google Maps, search:

> **[COMPETITOR]**

Open the business, click **Reviews**, then **Sort** and choose **Lowest**. Then sort again by **Highest**.

Search 2. In Google, to find more competitors to check:

> **[NICHE] [CITY] reviews**

Filled example: `business coach London reviews`

- **What to copy:** in the 1 to 3 star reviews, the sentence that says what they paid for and never got. In the 5 star reviews, the sentence that describes their life before.
- **Sort it:** low stars go mostly to FEAR. High stars give you DESIRE (what finally worked) and their "before", which is often FEAR in hindsight.

Online-only business with few Google reviews? Spend this time on section 2 instead.

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2. Review sites (3 minutes)

Search 3. In Google:

> **site:trustpilot.com "[PAIN]" [NICHE]**

Filled example: `site:trustpilot.com "zero sales" appointment setting`

Search 4. On a competitor's own Trustpilot page, add the star filter to the address:

> **https://www.trustpilot.com/review/[COMPETITOR WEBSITE]?stars=1&stars=2**

For agencies, try Clutch the same way: `site:clutch.co "[PAIN]" [NICHE]`.

- **What to copy:** the sentence where they explain why they bought, and the one where they explain what went wrong. Five star reviews often open with the problem in one line: our hook for this video came from one. "2 years of posting content, running ads, and praying someone books a call." (Trustpilot, 5 stars, 20 Aug 2025)
- **Sort it:** "why they bought" is DESIRE. "What went wrong" is FEAR. Anything about how they see themselves ("as a small agency") is IDENTITY.

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3. Reddit (3 minutes)

Search 5. In Google:

> **site:reddit.com "[PAIN]" [NICHE]**

Filled example: `site:reddit.com "feast or famine" agency owner`

Search 6. In Google, to find the threads where they ask for help:

> **site:reddit.com [NICHE] "how do you get clients" OR "where do you find clients"**

Filled example: `site:reddit.com coach "how do you get clients" OR "where do you find clients"`

Open the threads with the most comments. Read the comments, not just the post.

- **What to copy:** the comment where someone describes their own situation in one or two lines. Example: "I already tried everything in this space, from working with other coaches to Ads, cold DMs... I guess that's it." (r/lifecoaching, 14 Sep 2026)
- **Sort it:** the problem in their words is FEAR. The question they ask is DESIRE. "I'm a solo..." or "as a coach..." is IDENTITY.

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4. Newsletter and Substack comments (3 minutes)

Search 7. In Google:

> **site:substack.com "[PAIN]" [NICHE]**

Filled example: `site:substack.com "race to the bottom" consultant`

Search 8. In Google, for posts where owners tell their own story:

> **site:substack.com [NICHE] "worst month" OR "lost my biggest client" OR "almost quit"**

Open a post, then scroll to the comments under it.

- **What to copy:** the post author's one-line confession, and comments that start with "This is me" or "Same". People in comments write about themselves more honestly than on their own pages.
- **Sort it:** confessions are usually IDENTITY or FEAR. "I wish someone had told me..." is DESIRE.

5. YouTube comments (3 minutes)

Search 9. In the YouTube search box:

> **how to get [NICHE] clients**

Filled example: **how to get coaching clients**

Search 10. In the YouTube search box:

> **[NICHE] [PAIN]**

Filled example: **agency owner inconsistent clients**

Pick a video with many comments. Under the video, sort comments by **Top**, then scroll.

- **What to copy:** comments that start with their situation ("I've been coaching for 2 years and..."). Skip the "great video" ones.
- **Sort it:** their situation is FEAR or IDENTITY. What they say they'll try now is DESIRE.

6. Public Facebook groups (3 minutes)

Search 11. In the Facebook search bar, then click the **Groups** filter:

> **[NICHE]**

Filled example: **coaches** or **agency owners**

Join or open one or two **public** groups with recent posts.

Search 12. Inside the group, use the group's own search box:

> **[PAIN]**

Filled example: **clients** or **slow month**

- **What to copy:** posts that ask "has anyone else...", and the replies that share a number or a story.
- **Sort it:** "has anyone else..." is FEAR. "Looking for advice on..." is DESIRE. "As a new coach..." is IDENTITY.
- Only read public groups, and never copy names. You are collecting sentences, not people.

When the 20 minutes are up

You should have 9 to 15 sentences in three columns. Now:

1. **Circle the sentence that made you wince.** That is your next hook. Use it word for word as the first line of a post or the first words of a video.
2. **Count your columns.** Fewer than 3 sentences in one column means you don't know that part of your buyer yet. An empty FEAR column usually means your content is too polite. An empty IDENTITY column usually means your offer reads like everyone else's.
3. **Do it again next month.** The words change as the market changes.

What we do with this

This sheet is step 1 of what we build for clients: **research** before any content. We collect hundreds of sentences, not 15, from the buyers, the competitors and the market, and build the offer, the content and the ads from them, in that order.

If your columns came out thin, or full but you don't know what to do with them, reply to our DM with **"columns"** and tell us your niche.

*StraightScale · @straightscale_*